



Sure Access to Success



DANGLING PARTICIPLES

Prof. Tommy Cherian
8547006780



DANGLING PARTICIPLES

- A **dangling** participle is a phrase that does not have a subject inside a sentence. The subject used in a dangling participle is not the doer of the action expressed by the participle.

Example:

Deceived by his friends, hope was lost.



Dangling Participles (-ing Form & Past Participle)

- A dangling participle occurs when a grammatical modifier (usually a participial phrase) is not logically connected to the subject of the main clause. In a well-constructed sentence, the person or thing performing the action in the participle phrase must be the same as the subject of the sentence.
- When they differ, the modifier "dangles," often creating unintentional humour or logical confusion.

Walking down the street, the trees were beautiful.

This sentence suggests that the **trees** were walking down the street.

Dangling Participles (-ing Form & Past Participle)

Walking down the street, the trees were beautiful.

This sentence suggests that the **trees** were walking down the street.

The Correction:

Walking down the street, I thought the trees were beautiful.

Dangling Participles (*-ing Form & Past Participle*)

Why it happens?

Dangling participles usually occur because the writer is thinking about the action but forgets to state who is performing it, or they inadvertently use a **passive voice** construction.

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Incorrect (Dangling)	Why it's wrong	Corrected Version
Having finished the assignment , the TV was turned on.	The TV did not finish the assignment.	Having finished the assignment , James turned on the TV.
Planted in early spring , we harvested the tomatoes in July.	"We" were not planted in early spring.	Planted in early spring , the tomatoes were harvested in July.
Being a teacher , the students respect me.	The "students" are not the teacher; "I" am.	Being a teacher , I am respected by the students.

Dangling Participles: How to fix it?

Having finished the assignment, the TV was turned on.

Apply these **three** scholarly checks:

1. **Check the Subject:** Look at the first noun after the comma. Is that noun capable of doing the action described in the opening phrase?
2. **The "Who?" Test:** Ask yourself, "Who is doing the [verb]-ing?" If that person isn't the subject of the sentence, it's a dangling participle.
3. **Restructuring:** You can fix it in two ways:
 - Change the subject of the main clause to match the modifier.
 - Turn the introductory phrase into a full dependent clause (e.g., change "While running..." to "While I was running...").

Dangling Participles: How to fix it?

Having finished the assignment, the TV was turned on.

Apply these **three** scholarly checks:

1. Check the Subject:

Look at the first noun after the comma. Is that noun **(the TV)**, capable of doing the action described in the opening phrase?

The TV having finished the assignment.....?????

Dangling Participles: How to fix it?

Being a teacher, the students respect me.

Apply these **three** scholarly checks:

2. The "Who?" Test:

Ask yourself, "Who is doing the [verb]-ing?" If that person isn't the subject of the sentence, it's a dangling participle.

The students being a teacher....????

Dangling Participles: How to fix it?

Having finished the assignment, the TV was turned on.

3. **Restructuring:** You can fix it in two ways:

a) Change the subject of the main clause to match the modifier.

- *Having finished the assignment, the TV was turned on.?????*
- *Having finished the assignment, **James** turned on the TV.*

Dangling Participles: How to fix it?

3. Restructuring: You can fix it in two ways:

b. Turn the introductory phrase into a full dependent clause.

(E.g., change "**While running...**" to "**While I was running...**").

- While running, a dog bit me.???????
- While **I** was running, a dog bit me

Dangling Participles: How to fix it?

Having finished the assignment, the TV was turned on.

3. Restructuring:

Sentence	Logical Meaning	Grammatical Status
<i>While running, a dog bit me.</i>	The dog was running.	Incorrect (Dangling)
<i>While running, I was bitten by a dog.</i>	I was running.	Correct (Matched)
<i>While I was running, a dog bit me.</i>	I was running.	Correct (Clause)

Dangling Participles: Exceptions

"fixed" participles (sometimes called **unattached** or **impersonal participles**) are fascinating because they appear to be dangling but are actually grammatically acceptable.

Dangling Participles: Exceptions

Certain "fixed" or absolute participles are grammatically accepted because they function more like prepositions or adverbs. These do not "dangle" even if they don't match the subject:

- *Judging by the clouds, it will rain.*
- *Generally speaking, cats dislike water.*
- *Considering the circumstances, you did well.*

In these cases, the phrases are considered independent of the sentence's primary subject.

Dangling Participles: Exceptions

1. The "Judgment" Group

These are used by the speaker to provide a perspective or a basis for the statement that follows.

- **Considering:** *Considering the lack of evidence, the case was dismissed.* (The "case" isn't doing the considering; the judge or speaker is.)
- **Judging:** *Judging by his reaction, he was surprised.*
- **Taking:** *Taking everything into account, the plan is sound.*

Dangling Participles: Exceptions

2. The "Communication" Group

These introduce a general observation or a way of speaking.

- **Broadly/Generally speaking:** *Generally speaking, the results were positive.*
- **Strictly speaking:** *Strictly speaking, a tomato is a fruit.*
- **Granting/Granted:** *Granted his talent, he still needs to work hard.*

Dangling Participles: Exceptions

3. The "Reference" Group

These function almost exactly like prepositions such as "about" or "regarding."

- **Regarding:** *Regarding your application, a decision will be made soon.*
- **Concerning:** *Concerning the new policy, many questions remain.*
- **Providing/Provided:** *Provided that the weather stays clear, we will leave at dawn.*

Dangling Participles: Exceptions

4. The "Exclusion" Group

- **Barring:** *Barring any last-minute delays, the project will finish on time.*
- **Excepting:** *Excepting the final chapter, the book is excellent.*

Absolute Phrases **vs.** Fixed Participles

Absolute Phrase:

Includes its own noun as a subject.

Example: **The sun having set**, we returned home.

(The "sun" is the subject of "having set.")

Fixed Participle:

Has no explicit subject, but is accepted as an independent adverbial modifier.

Example: **Roughly speaking**, the distance is ten miles.

(No noun is "speaking.")

Let's Check!

1. Identify the grammatically incorrect sentence:

- A) Standing on the balcony, the view was breathtaking.
- B) Standing on the balcony, I enjoyed the breathtaking view.
- C) While I was standing on the balcony, the view was breathtaking.
- D) From the balcony, the view was breathtaking.

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2. Correct the sentence: "Having finished the exam, the room was vacated."

- A) Having finished the exam, the students vacated the room.
- B) The exam being finished, the room was vacated.
- C) After finishing the exam, the room was empty.
- D) Both A and B are grammatically acceptable.

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- A) Having finished the exam, the students vacated the room.
- B) The exam being finished, the room was vacated. (*Absolute Construction*)
- C) After finishing the exam, the room was empty.
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3. Which sentence is logically sound?

- A) Barking loudly, I saw a dog in the street.
- B) Running late, the bus had already left.
- C) Weighted down with books, the backpack felt heavy to the student.
- D) Knowing the truth, the secret was finally revealed.

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4. Choose the correct version of: "While driving to work, a deer ran across the road."

- A) While driving to work, the road was crossed by a deer.
- B) While I was driving to work, a deer ran across the road.
- C) Driving to work, the deer was seen by me.
- D) A deer, while driving to work, ran across the road.

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"Young and inexperienced" refers to "him," but grammatically it modifies "the task." Tasks cannot be "young."

Correct it!

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Corrected:

"Young and inexperienced, **he** found the task impossible."

6. Select the grammatically correct sentence:

- A) To qualify for the scholarship, your grades must be high.
- B) To qualify for the scholarship, a student must have high grades.
- C) By studying hard, the scholarship was won.
- D) Hoping for a miracle, the exam was started.

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"To qualify" is an infinitive phrase acting as a modifier.
The "student" is the one qualifying, not the "grades."

7. Which of the following is a "Dangling Participle"?

- A) Looking through the window, the rain began to fall.
- B) As I looked through the window, the rain began to fall.
- C) Looking through the window, I saw the rain fall.
- D) The rain began to fall as I looked through the window.

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8. Correct this sentence: "Being a rainy day, I stayed indoors."

- A) It being a rainy day, I stayed indoors.
- B) Because of a rainy day, I stayed indoors.
- C) Being that it was rainy, I stayed indoors.
- D) All of the above.

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9. Choose the sentence that avoids ambiguity:

- A) Tired after the long journey, sleep was necessary.
- B) Tired after the long journey, the bed looked inviting.
- C) Tired after the long journey, the traveller went to bed.
- D) After a long journey, sleep was tired.

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10. Which sentence uses a "Fixed/Absolute Participle" (an exception to the dangling rule)?

- A) Walking home, it began to snow.
- B) Considering the weather, the match was cancelled.
- C) Eating dinner, the phone rang.
- D) Sitting on the grass, a snake bit him.

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